

Five Days Out

September 2026 · To the AC300/AC375 Class

To my AC300/AC375 classmates,

Five days out, I wanted to actually write this down instead of just saying it in passing between classes. However you're feeling right now -- steady, wired, a little scared, honestly probably all three at once -- that's completely normal five days out from a comprehensive final. But I want to say something plainly, as someone who studies exactly this for a living: you are more ready than it feels like tonight.

There's a real reason for the gap between how ready you feel and how ready you actually are, and it's not really about how much you know. In motivation research we call it expectancy -- your belief that you'll succeed -- and expectancy gets quietly worn down by fatigue, repetition, and plain exhaustion in ways that have nothing to do with your actual competence. If you're feeling shaky tonight, that's mostly your nervous system talking. It is not new information about how prepared you are.

What actually rebuilds expectancy isn't reassurance -- it's mastery experience. Concrete proof you've already succeeded at the thing you're worried about, not just someone telling you it'll be fine. And we have that in real quantity: nine weeks of quizzes, a review week built specifically to pull it all together, every point pathway any of us drilled again after missing it the first time. I built out a full set of extra study materials this term partly because turning the material into something concrete helped me feel less at the mercy of my own pre-exam anxiety, and if any of it helped you too, that's the exact kind of evidence I mean -- proof, not a pep talk.

The value of all this was never really in question either. None of us ended up in a Chinese medicine program by accident. Whatever pulled you here in the first place is still true Wednesday morning, whether or not Wednesday morning itself feels calm. This exam is one moment inside something you actually care about, not the whole of it.

So here's what I'd actually ask of all of us the next five days: protect your sleep over one more late read-through. Trust confirming what you already know over trying to force in something new at 11pm. And if your stomach drops Tuesday night, that's not new information about your readiness either -- that's just what final exams feel like, to everyone, regardless of how prepared they are.

We've done the work. Let Wednesday just be the day we show it.

Rooting for all of us,

Jon